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8 Collaborative reflexive inquiry into parliaments

Ethnographers negotiating during research on politics

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Just as democratic politics arises out of difference and requires negotiation, so too does research into politics. Researchers of parliaments and other political institutions used to keep their social distance from those they were studying by surveying, polling and looking at texts or increasingly digital communication and televised proceedings (Crewe 2021, 25–6).[1] As ethnographers, in contrast, we rely on finding ways to get close to people in institutions on the assumption that our research questions have demanded it; distance can blunt one's capacity to take account of plurality and difference. Although anthropologists have managed to produce significant analysis through the study of texts and public meetings from afar (e.g. Teixeira's work on honour in the Brazilian Congress 2004a), our own research would not have been possible without creating the possibility of close physical proximity to social actors in political institutions.

Proximity to interlocutors brings with it challenges. If you do manage to get close, then how do you retain enough impartiality to analyse with detachment? What happens to criticality if you get too close? How do you avoid merely replicating the interlocutors' viewpoint, which at best is an infinitely rich series of accounts of a political world but sometimes a profoundly distorted one? As Teixeira et al. put it, "How is one to do ethnographic work with people like politicians, who usually hold secrets and tell lies?" (2020, 545). And how do we deal with the complexity of parliaments given that, as Teixeira notes

> the very social setting where these studies take place is highly complex, involving wide public circulation, spatial dispersion, vast networks of people, things and symbols, capillary power relations, and forms of material production of life.
>
> (2020, 547)

So, whilst anthropologists have long been arguing for more collaborative innovation in the co-production of knowledge (e.g. Ingold 2018; Lassiter 2005), for both intellectual and moral-political reasons, this has often focused on how lone researchers can engage in new ways with various interlocutors and

DOI: 10.4324/9781003356349-12

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publics. We join the smaller number of scholars considering the nature of collaboration between researchers (e.g., Tuula et al. 2006). If aiming to develop systematic ways of approaching research to develop anthropological rigour in political institutions, we argue that various processes are significantly enriched by being constituted as a diverse research team using (1) a larger range of contacts, networks and tactics to gain access; (2) continual critical debate within the team benefiting from our diverse histories, perspectives and disciplines; (3) imagination to fathom what happens in political (including postcolonial) encounters between our own habitus, history and identity and those of our interlocutors including politicians and (4) improvised practical judgements to gain a sense of proportion, learn from plural audiences, navigate ethical challenges and influence towards the public good. Marc Abélès has written about the advantages of working as a diverse research team, but they allowed each other greater autonomy when researching the World Trade Organization than the example we are concerned with in this chapter (2017, 37). We found that the encounter of difference as researchers within a small team brings with it complexities when you give up your autonomy, even if only temporarily in this specific case. We worked as a collective for a brief period, after two years of working closely in a coalition (in an European Research Council-funded programme nicknamed EoPPP; see footnote 1), raising questions about how we should navigate fundamentally different viewpoints – whether emerging out of individual and cultural histories, disciplines or politics – without losing either integrity or intelligibility. What risks are involved for those in their traditional field-site receiving visiting anthropologists? Critically, what kinds of negotiation are needed in the process of studying politics as a small team and how it is shaped in part by prior relationships?

In this chapter, we begin by reflecting on others' and our own histories of developing innovative approaches to using ethnographic methods to explain how new habits for collaboration emerged out of our own experience. We draw briefly on narratives from our own research, contrasting the approach of sole-authored research (e.g. Hoyler 2022) with joint projects (Crewe and Sarra 2019, Bernardes and Nunez 2021), collaborative coalition research (Cornwall 2006) and participatory methods where the informants themselves became researchers (Cornwall 2011, Crewe and Walker 2019). We then explore the experience of brief collective ethnographic research undertaken as four researchers together in São Paulo in August 2022. We reflect on what impact these different approaches had on criticality, reflexivity and rigour and explain how and why negotiation is a central process to more intensive collaborative research methods.

Ethnographies of parliaments and other governance institutions

Ethnography is becoming an established approach to researching parliaments and other political institutions, even if there is considerable disagreement about what that means (Crewe 2021, 17, 26, 57–58), whilst our

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chapter more specifically focuses on *collaborative* ethnographic inquiries into politics. What Gerstl-Pepin and Gunzenhauser (2002) refer to as "team ethnography" does not necessarily make research easier. As different epistemological assumptions, research paradigms, races, genders, class backgrounds and research interests combine and get involved in what Bakhtin (1986) calls the "interpretive zone," complications and conflicts can emerge that then become part of the research process. The performative pedagogical act of collective interpretation tends to lead to messy research findings. This is also clear from many of the contributions to a journal that focuses entirely on "Entanglements: experiments in multimodal ethnography," established in 2018.[2] We will argue here that this messiness gets amplified in political domains where the contestation of knowledge is especially pervasive and fraught with reputational risks for politicians who are so often exposed to public attack just as they are trying to win support.

To account for key aspects of our own predispositions, as well as introducing various strategies for navigating the complexities of researching politics, we will explain our own research backgrounds, interests and experiences. This is essential for then narrating our joint research in a reflexive way in the next section. As a professional journalist hired as a civil servant from the Brazilian Congress since 2005, Cristiane Bernardes has developed an ethnography of legislative media focused on the intersection of political, institutional and public communication inside and about the parliament. Interdisciplinarity was at the core of this work, since the empirical matter was analysing the processes, routines and relationships involved in the production of journalistic information about the parliament (Bernardes 2013, 2015). Following Bourdieu's (2005) considerations about the centrality of politicians, scientists and journalists for the production of symbolic capital, Cristiane has described how the parliamentarians and the journalists from legislative media – who are also civil servants from the house in their vast majority – operate daily to produce political discourses that will be disseminated through the media system around the country. Recently, the debate about the constraints of researching institutions from which we belong (Bernardes and Nunez 2021) leads to a reflection about the conditionalities of this "triple identity": journalist + civil servant + researcher. The study has shown how these intertwined and, sometimes, conflictive identities can function as a way of boosting reflexivity in the research. These overlapping identities constituted a source for the reflection about researcher positionality, an insight that became essential to analysing the collaborative ethnography explained in this chapter.

Andrea Cornwall, a British anthropologist with a long-standing relationship with Brazil, first got interested in the politics of participatory governance in Brazil in the first Lula administration (2003–2007). Researching a municipal participatory governance institution over a period of almost a decade, through different conjunctures of political party at the municipal and state level, different styles of leadership of the *conselho*, different configurations

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of civil society actors and different modes of engagement by those who saw and used the *conselho* as a space for their political projects, brought Andrea to an interest in electoral politics. Working with the late Brazilian political scientist Ana Alice Costa (Costa and Cornwall 2014) and Pernambuco's State Secretary for Women's Policies, Cristina Buarque, co-founder of *Mulher e Democracia*, Andrea became interested in pathways into political office for historically marginalized groups and questions of representation, interests and voice in political institutions. Her interest in this project was primarily methodological, exploring both the contribution that ethnography can make to the study of political institutions and the possibilities of collective ethnography. As a temporary visitor to the project, she played a vital role by bringing expertise about participatory governance in conversations, but also playfully questioning the received wisdom of the project.

Emma Crewe, a British anthropologist, began her ethnographies of the two Houses of Westminster Parliament in 1998. To get under the skin of politicians – and fathom not only the nature of their chaotic, shapeshifting work but also the continuities in how they do politics – she relied on reflexivity, multidisciplinarity and attention to plurality. Three research experiences took Emma down the route of collaborative ethnography. She joined with a colleague, Nicholas Sarra, a psychotherapist and group analyst, to research MPs in their constituencies. In the struggle to understand what interlocutors were saying, thinking and feeling, they used their imagination in an embodied way – as if discerning emotion by feeling some aspect of it themselves (Crewe and Sarra 2019, 2021). Secondly, she was invited to undertake a joint piece of research into the UK Parliament's expenses scandal of 2009 with the official who was responsible for overseeing the MPs' salaries and expenses regime – Andrew Walker. The research benefited from Andrew's insider knowledge of the history of the scandal and Emma's detachment as an outsider, but only because they jointly wrestled over the problem of partiality every step of the way (2019). Thirdly, during a research coalition AuQ22 that awarded grants to scholars in Ethiopia and Myanmar, an School of Oriental and African Studies (SOAS) team compiled a collective fieldwork log over several years to create a participatory ethnographic evaluation of the coalition's work from plural perspectives[3] (Axelby, Worku-Dix, and Crewe 2022). She brought prior embodied knowledge about how encounters between researchers are shaped not only by processes of being both an insider and an outsider but also by practical experience of gathering collective field notes.

Telma Hoyler, also a Brazilian researcher, has recently obtained her PhD degree in political science defending a thesis about territorial political representation in the city. She first watched councillors inside official spaces of the chamber and followed two of them (one from centre-left and another from centre-right political parties) and their brokers (formal or informal advisors who link people to institutionalized instances of public authority) in the territories they worked to create and maintain during the entire incumbency

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period. The research engaged with the question of how politicians build and operate connections with constituents in political systems with large electoral districts covering extensive populations and territories and how their strategies are embedded in both territories and political parties. Although the thesis process, as it usually is – was a solitary process, it relied on other experiences of field research and collective reflections in consultancies she had previously provided to organizations (2010–2013) and in partnerships she had established to reflect and write about her work as an advisor in the City Hall of São Paulo (2014–2017). The network she built up was what enabled her to arrange all of the encounters involved in this collective experience of research, using her social capital in the middle of a year-long period of ethnography conducted under the aegis of the EoPPP.

As the four of us converged to work collectively in São Paulo in August 2022, we reflected on what connected us as researchers. We share an interest in relational theories on political worlds – inquiring into the entanglements of knowledge, power, inequality and meaning-making. We have all experimented with method and dissented with established ways of doing research; as people open to innovation and challenge, we were perhaps predisposed to a mode of working that involved making something up as we were going along, reflecting critically on what we were doing as well as what we were learning, and challenging ourselves and each other. Openness, including to self-critique, was an important part of our process. Our conversations ranged from what each of us had brought into and taken from our ethnographic encounters, to reflections on what it meant to see things through the cultural lenses we had acquired, including what Robert Chambers calls "self-critical epistemological awareness" about the blind spots, biases and habits of mind we had got into.[4]

What made us different from each other went beyond the obvious differences of nationality, discipline and education – although it is worth noting that all of us had experienced the discipline of political science, whether doing PhDs in political science or collaborating with political scientists. Our different life experiences and positionalities worked to create different reactions to situations we found ourselves in. For example, this had Emma remarking in our collective field notes how happy she was to find herself in the familiar territory of a legislature, Telma being quite at ease in a bureaucrat's office on the top floor of a São Paulo tower block, Cristiane finding that a politician's "territory" we visited looked like the place she grew up in and Andrea being curious about the similarity between a politician's constituency office and a private health clinic. We brought different dispositions to asking questions and processing what we were learning with and from each other. And we all had different strands we were more interested in as part of our collective enquiry, although these were more immanent and emergent than explicit in how we went about our research. As influential as our differences were, the relationships between us were as relevant to the research process, as we go on to narrate.

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Collaborative reflexive inquiry: a São Paulo experiment

In August 2022 we assembled in São Paulo, with the initial goal of spending the week together exploring the use of ethnography for the study of Brazilian political institutions. Emma Crewe and Andrea Cornwall, both political anthropologists who had worked together at SOAS for four years, were visiting Cristiane Bernardes, a communications scholar based in Brasilia, and Telma Hoyler, an urban studies scholar based in São Paulo, as part of EoPPP. Emma and Cristiane had worked together for two years and with Telma for six months. Until a few weeks before, Andrea had been pro-director of Research and Enterprise at SOAS, at the level of Emma's manager's manager. Emma was the principal investigator on a project on which Cristiane was a senior researcher, leading on the Brazil research, and Telma was a junior researcher, reporting to Cristiane. This whole chain of hierarchy could have been hard to cope with in a less collaborative environment, but we were aware of it since the beginning of the project, so we did not allow it to interfere with recognition of the specific skills, experience and abilities each one of us have. Furthermore, during these shared encounters, we further developed intense friendships that are familiar to all ethnographers but more usually with interlocutors (Owton et al. 2014). The diversity, hierarchies and friendships led us to notice and interpret in variable ways, depending on our language ability as an example, and even to create disagreement and tension, but to be able to discuss and learn from each other with an extraordinary intensity at the same time.

Collaborative research in action

Telma had scheduled visits to a wide range of events including rallies, as parties were campaigning for the 2022 election; interviews with politicians, citizens and civil servants; and visits to political institutions (including to the São Paulo City Hall, the City Council and the Legislative Assembly), as well as places of political and cultural significance (museums, art galleries and markets). On our first day, Emma had the idea of us creating a collective fieldwork log and proposed a process to pool our field notes on a shared Google Doc. We agreed on the terms of the fieldwork log of our week in São Paulo with the following introduction:

> *We can begin with recording our first impressions and then add key reflections on each day. We won't have time to record all our handwritten fieldnotes but we might select what we thought was most interesting, significant or surprising. As we go we can write in our own colour (with our Initials at the end of the note) but also react to each other's notes with further notes or even using the comments function. Disagreements, jokes and stories are especially welcome as that will enrich our understanding. In this log we want to reflect on what we learn about*

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> *politicians and people they interact with. Of course, this means understanding the context they live and work in. But we are also interested in reflection on how we see, listen, pay attention, ignore, make sense, read emotions, interpret and then write about our impressions. How we do this will be different for us due to our histories, our mood, discipline and nationality, our previous knowledge and or prejudices. So include anything in this fieldwork log that reveals your reflections but also how you came to them. Also respond to other people's reflections with comments, agreements, disagreements, additions, expressions of confusion – anything pertinent. By participating in this document you sign up to our ethical framework[5] which demands that any research participants' identity has to be anonymised unless you have permission from them. Give yourself a colour so we can easily see who has written what and put your initial at the end of text.*
>
> (Google Doc created on 22 August 2022)

We travelled to the various encounters as a foursome between 20 and 29 August 2022, discussing what we thought about each in between arranged meetings or events, and at breakfast, lunch and dinner, and then writing into the log late at night or very early in the morning. Between us, we wrote 20 pages (about 12.5K words) of field notes into the shared Google Doc. This was but a fraction of the "data" noted down by pen during the encounters and created through conversation. In the Google Doc, mostly we informed and conversed with each other about what we had seen, how we felt about it and how our observations were influenced by our own presuppositions and histories, by using different coloured text. From time to time, one of us used the comment function to respond to another researcher's observation or responded to entries made in the log itself. The log became a multilayered conversation. Initial impressions recorded by one were elaborated by another, and a thread of reflection was started and continued as we took our turns writing into the shared document. On 29 August 2022, we dispersed – Andrea back to London, Telma remaining in São Paulo, whilst Cristiane and Emma continued to do fieldwork in Curitiba (30 August to 2 September 2022) and then finally in Brasilia (until 8 September 2022) with Telma again.

During a period of ten days, we produced insights of far greater volume, depth, rigour and significance than we could conceivably have done on our own in months. The enhancement of our insights was not the mere product of being a group, more minds and bodies decided to the task, but it emerged out of the differences between us. Rather than assuming that those differences would create partiality, and therefore diminish our capacity for impartiality, we explored them as part of the research. Language was an obvious example. Cristiane and Telma had Portuguese as their first language, Andrea spoke it fluently, but Emma not at all. During conversations with our interlocutors, as Emma could not understand the content, she paid much more attention

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to non-verbal elements of communication such as body language and items decorating the rooms. In meetings, we were able to ask obvious questions for the benefit of the foreigners, providing opportunities to interrogate the meanings that participants gave to concepts in ways that would have been considered strange for a first-language speaker to do, because locals are expected to know specific aspects about their own environment.

After the meetings, the interrogation of key political concepts, the difficulties of translating certain words and concepts into English led to generative conversations about what was going on in terms of political work. To give some examples, the literal translation of "*gabinete*" to "cabinet," "*mandato*" to "mandate," "territorial based voters" to "constituencies" and "*dobrada eleitoral*" to "electoral alignment" would distort what these mean in practice in Brazil. Unpacking these terms and exploring their situated meanings not only brought into sharp relief the value of an ethnographic approach, but it also served to underscore that political institutions are produced and performed according to the cultural contexts where they are made, meaning they are never exactly the same in different political communities and territories. Not by chance, the passion to scrutinize words through different cultures has been at the core of anthropologists' efforts to unfold what is universal and what is specific to certain contexts; as Abélès (1999) has stated, translation is not only a linguistic but also a cultural matter.

Let's take *mandato* as an example to see how our collective process helped reveal new facets of the concept. In Brazil, "mandato" designates the group surrounding the politician and is an important part of the explanation of how politicians build and operate connections with voters in a political system with large electoral districts, in territorial extension and population. During our collective fieldwork, because the subject was new to Andrea, Emma and Cristiane and because they were outsiders (in different ways), they could more freely ask brokers and politicians "What is a mandate?" repeatedly in different encounters, without worrying that they might appear ignorant. For Telma, who had been studying this very question for the previous four years, this enabled her to hear replies to a question that might have been odd if posed by someone who was unambiguously an insider to the specific political context. And by asking the question, we got interestingly different answers. Sometimes the mandate would be characterized as a "space to do things" or a "group" or a "political project." At other times, it was about the time within which the mantle of legitimacy would give a politician agency to make demands. Such answers made Telma think about incorporating more seriously these slightly different perceptions of a mandate in the theory she has been developing and how it affects how decisions are made inside mandates. Furthermore, it made us reflect more generally on a sense of timing in the research process: when is it appropriate to assume we know something in a settled way and when is it wise to keep asking the same question over and over again? This in itself is one of the contributions that ethnography makes to the study of political institutions: never taking things at face value and

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remaining curious and open to a diversity of versions and meanings. Being a diverse team ourselves in terms of nationality and discipline enhanced the potential for interrogating this fluidity of meaning and diversity of perspectives, as Abélès found at the WTO (2017).

Working as a collective allowed us to deploy our knowledge and our ignorance in ways that strengthened our capacity both to inquire and to understand. Explaining something to a foreigner involves acts of description and framing that can shed new light on the familiar. After all, as Taussig puts it, "The whole point of anthropology is to be cast outside of yourself, lose your moorings, and, equally if not even more important, figure out a way – a poetics – of 'translating' this new experience into terms that the reader can latch onto" (2009, 2071). Having a foreign senior researcher ask a question that might sound naïve coming from a more junior local researcher could open up reflections that might be otherwise more difficult to come by, just as having people deeply familiar with the political context in the team can help get to the nub of things in a way that would be simply out of reach to someone unfamiliar with the context. Different meanings of concepts, and even different cultural realities, come into view; the process of dialogue and joint dissection of ethnographic encounters from the multiple perspectives of four researchers helps bring those differences into play in the process of weaving together an analysis. Whilst facing the challenges of studying up (Nader 1972), especially in gendered relations and with young researchers, showing we have some knowledge as researchers can help create a different balance with the interviewee.

Reflexivity and relationships between researchers

The essence of reflexivity is thinking about how and why you relate to the research in the ways that you do and how that has an impact on your questions and conclusions. It is not only anthropologists who think about reflexivity. Alvesson and Skøldberg write about how reflexivity depends on paying attention to "the way different kinds of linguistic, social, political and theoretical elements are woven together in the process of knowledge development, during which empirical material is constructed, interpreted and written" (2009, 9). For them, reflexivity depends on four elements: (1) rigorous methods of data collection, (2) seeing research as a process as interpretation, (3) including attention to the politics of the process including one's own ideology and (4) questioning the separation between author as subject and the reality being studied (ibid., 11). We agree that to be reflexive in creating a text that is important to enquire into one's own identity or narrative about oneself. This calls for us to work towards a pluralistic ideal whereby different voices pervade the text (ibid., 197, 213).

In this mini-project, we have plural authors in addition to a plurality of voices amongst interlocutors. The complexity of this plurality means that it can never be complete, and the terms of inclusion can vary for all involved

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because everyone has a different combination of identities, histories and interests. Working out on what basis people come to be included or left out is complex because everyone's identity is multiple and dynamic. A woman is not just a woman but has many aspects to her life that influence what constrains and enables her – age, class, sexuality, profession, residence, political ideology, etc. – and all this needs to be considered amongst both interlocutors and researchers, not only when undertaking data collection but also when interpreting that data. If our research group had included men or disabled people, they too would have had their own impact inflected by gender and disability, but also much too. The reflection on representation can never be complete, so partial representation is worth scrutiny but should not paralyse the research process.

Alvesson and Skøldberg's exploration of reflexivity neglects three aspects, which are arguably also underplayed by other qualitative social researchers relying on hermeneutics: disciplinary difference, relationships between all those involved and the need for negotiation. As researchers practising inter- or multi-disciplinarity, Alvesson and Skøldberg write little about how different disciplines amongst qualitative researchers fundamentally affect how researchers make and communicate knowledge. In the practice of working together, it was the experience of debriefing after encounters that drew our attention to these additional aspects of reflexivity. Two of us in this São Paulo experience were anthropologists (Andrea and Emma), one from urban studies (Telma Hoyler) and the fourth a communications scholar (Cristiane Bernardes). Our disciplinary training led us to notice or be drawn to different inquiries within the shared project of collaborative ethnography. To give an example, when deciding who to schedule interviews with, Telma was interested in exploring how the development of politicians' support depended on complex networks of brokers and intermediaries in the face-to-face political territories where they focused their attention. Cristiane's focus, in contrast, was on understanding a newer phenomenon: the use of digital media by politicians to win support by virtual means, including the rise of WhatsApp. In the desire to accommodate everyone's interests, and bearing in mind that Cristiane is Telma's manager, our interviewing schedule included both types of encounters. What we noticed and remarked upon also reflected not only our different positionalities and disciplinary training but also further intersections within our disciplines with others. Andrea became fascinated with the iconography of politicians' offices and the politics of their self-representations, whilst Emma brought us back time and again to reflect on the centrality of relationships to politics and to our relationships with each other. Decisions about what to focus on when emerged not only out of these interests but also after endless negotiations between us, constrained and enabled by the complex relationships within our group. We were managing each other, researchers together but also at times friends and, at moments, like siblings negotiating over how to relate to each other and the world around us.

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As the week progressed, and we discussed each encounter with interlocutors – whether politicians, civil servants, journalists or social movement leaders – in the gaps between research events, the four of us tried to make sense of both brokerage and the use of digital media. It emerged in a conversation in the subsequent week in Brasilia, in part because decisions had to be made about the longer-term research plans, that this difference in emphasis was created in part out of the ideological differences of our primary disciplines. Unsurprisingly, as a communications specialist Cristiane saw the primacy of communications within politics, whilst Telma, an urban studies ethnographer, prioritized socio-political relations as constructed in real space, even if both perceived how these were entangled with other aspects. This led to a fruitful exploration about the need to find out how relationships constructed in space, and the use of digital media, are interwoven, rather than choosing between them in our development of theory. Interestingly enough, both scholars achieved their PhD in political science from different universities in Brazil, showing another layer of interdisciplinarity and field loyalties – or capital, in Bourdieu's terms (2005) – in their political perspectives. The familiar difficulty of working across disciplines is not just ideological or methodological then; in the sense of having different understandings about the world and different frames of reality, it is about the identity of scholars and the relationships between them. Interdisciplinarity requires negotiation as much as it does about learning from each other's assumptions.

The need for negotiation in collaborative research calls into question commonly held assumptions about how interpretation relies on an idea about separating researchers from interlocutors. A familiar picture of what happens is explained by Alvesson and Skøldberg: the researcher/s collect data from various interactions and events and then go away to embark on the task of interpretation. They see this as happening on various levels from "raw" interpretations at a low level of abstraction, to a consideration of underlying meanings to more critical reflection and then finally thinking about whose voice is being represented versus excluded (2009, 272–3). Thus, the authority of the researcher is established by expansive repertoires, whether through reflectivity, wide reading or being creative. Data are never simply collected but rather produced out of an encounter between those pursuing an inquiry and others who get involved. It is a complex process worthy of being part of the study, as Clifford pointed out 40 years ago (1983). He made clear that a controlling sole author is a fantasy even when anthropology appears to be a lonely process; in practice, "experiential, interpretive, dialogical and polyphonic processes are at work, discordantly, in any ethnography" (ibid., 142).

The agency of all those involved in the research includes the possibility that interlocutors are involved in meaning-making and interpretation during so-called data-collection. Ethnography can be carried out in a real collaborative process with interlocutors, who provide much of the meaning for the social practices we observed. When researchers are also part of the same political or cultural community and could be considered "natives"

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themselves, interpretations are deeply shared with informants, something that can boost collective reflexivity, since the movement recommended by Da Matta (1978) and Wahl-Jorgensen (2010) occur – changing the familiar to the exotic – which involves an emotional detachment from the observed social practices. Da Matta (1978, 5) points out that "the problem, then, is to lift the cover off a member of a class and a specific social group in order to be able – as an ethnologist – to discover some common social rule and then find . . . the exotic that is rooted within us by reification and legitimation mechanisms." Velho (1981) too highlights that reflexivity within environments well-known to the researcher involves denaturalizing the meanings attributed to social practices, in a way that allows us to pay attention to the meanings attributed by the subjects we observe.

When Crewe was interviewing politicians and journalists about the expenses scandal with one of the protagonists, they were all engaged in creating narratives about what happened, which involved "interpretation" from the moment the inquiry began. It was a collectively produced piece of history. During the São Paulo mini-project, those we engaged with had a significant impact on meaning-making, in different ways and to different extents. To give one example, when we interviewed a civil servant at the City Hall, the encounter was critically influenced not only by the long-standing relationship he had with one of us, which accelerated the process of establishing trust and understanding, but also by the fact that the rest of us were strangers to him. Our strangeness made it easy to ask what might seem obvious questions, to elicit his views rather than to merely collect facts. He explained his job within the context of a complex range of political processes within the municipality, the council and various participatory mechanisms. He did so with an astute eye for both detail and broad-brush explanations that were expansive enough for strangers and nuanced enough for someone already known to him.

In a way that is familiar in lone anthropological research, it was almost as if this civil servant became a temporary member of our team (or friendship group) for a few hours during conversations with him (even if he did not literally do so), such was his capacity to talk reflexively on the world of structures, procedures and relationships he described around him. We heard about how the proposals that emerge out of participatory democracy get deprioritized not merely for rational reasons – for example, cost, lack of alignment or other perception of barriers – but because politicians rankle at the symbolic demolition of representative democracy that may be conveyed by acting fast. He not only told stories about how politicians twist knowledge but also theorized about *why* and how he experienced and made sense of it. He told, for example, of how a politician had under-reported the cost of transport to force other politicians to ask for more funding at a later point, which would allow him to make an increase just before an election. In this way, this bureaucrat was not just an "informant" – as if imparting information – or an interlocutor – someone to talk with – but a co-creator of knowledge with us, in a way that was even more obvious than it was with other

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interlocutors. And that knowledge was "data," a telling of events, interactions and characters, but it was also "theory," an interpretation of how, why and with what consequences.

What felt like his very temporary incorporation into our team with exceptional speed, and at times surprising intensity, might have been more possible because we were a group rather than a lone researcher. It was as if the some of the intensity he had with one of us already became benignly distributed across the group, even if in a circumscribed way. Being a group with a theoretical collaboration already in play softened his interpretations to the kaleidoscope of ideas and abstractions we were developing together. They were not felt as a completely different or complementary perspective, as might have been the case if the encounter was with a lone visiting anthropologist. Being part of a group meant this informant shared his identity with us in a way that his positionality or hierarchical position could be integrated into a group that already was dealing with these issues internally. He wasn't the "other one" to us but just "another one" of us. An individual ethnographer might have interviewed the bureaucrat and co-produced knowledge together as a dialogue or even written a joint article. Because we were a team with a sense of professional intimacy and were in discussion about some of the things that he spoke about, the boundaries between the "researcher" and the "researched" were even more porous and fluid than usual, and this relationship was polyphonic, as Clifford puts in, and therefore a multilogue more than a dialogue. By inviting him into a conversation we were having between ourselves, the relationship became more intense and open to negotiating meaning – aided by Telma's long-standing relationship with him and the conversations that they had been having before our encounter. In this way, we could not only benefit from that relationship but bring him into our family-like relationships with each other within hours. This allowed us to interweave "data," "theory" and "analysis" in a much more iterative way than within the strictures of conventional political science, familiar to the traditional mould of the anthropological participant observer, but with extraordinary speed. This is a dimension of collaborative ethnography that invites further reflection.

Concluding remarks on negotiating collective doubt

In this article about doing ethnography, we have considered what is involved in negotiating to collaborate as researchers in a group. Although the different histories, identities and positionalities amongst us meant we had to temporarily give something up – Telma invested social capital by introducing us to informants, Cristiane and Emma gave up some of decision-making power by allowing more autonomy between the São Paulo and Brasilia aspects of the research and Andrea shifted her attention to researching elites – over time temporary losses turned into mostly gains. When seen in temporal terms, compromise in our group turned into co-operation with benefits to both individuals and the wider project.

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We have emphasized how the differences and intensity between us enriched our gaze and interpretation. We should also acknowledge that the shared aspects of our perspectives eased the process of making sense of what we found at the same time. We are interested in everyday politics operating in practice and all aim to avoid reductionist theories to explain how our interlocutors made decisions and navigated their political worlds. Like Wolford (2007), who wrote about social mobilization in northeast Brazil, we reject as explanation the marketplace of decision-making constructed by rational choice theory (Downs 1957; Tsebelis 2002), or the rule-following of new institutionalism (DiMaggio 1998), and assume people live with contradictions and in a state of confused fragmentation inside social relations. In their own ways, both approaches operate deductively, assuming how people think and deriving from that point hypothesis tests that could leave aside many different worlds of meaning and reasoning.

Despite shared elements in our worldview, encounters were never simple. Whilst an "interview" can be an encounter of narrative and theory-building with interlocutors, it is always complex – a negotiation between a plurality of interpretations. It is this aspect of research that tends to be ignored in accounts of methodology. But this negotiation has important consequences for the rigour of research. If we aim to get beyond the polarized choice between relativism and absolute truth, and correspondingly the inevitable subjectivity of theory versus the possibility of an objective account of the world, then the idea of negotiation helps explain the pragmatist philosopher's view of objectivity as a process rather than a fixed position. The need for negotiation arises because the correspondence between perception and reality may be easily established in some cases (e.g. a black cat passed by), but less so in other situations (e.g. almost everything in political domains). When an inquiry gets complex and contested, as it always does in politics, then agreement is not easily found, but the process in our experimental research was assisted by having a plurality of perspectives and close relationships within an existing team rather than a lone researcher. A research team could be viewed as a community of inquirers, as conceived by the philosopher Peirce, who dissuades each other from excessive certainty or narrowness (1955). If that community has an expansive and worldly enough repertoire, and the capacity for exposing biases and negotiating seemingly conflicting narratives and meanings, then they can work towards a persuasive agreed account. Our already established friendships were key to this temporary community of inquirers having what felt like a heightened capacity for collaboration.

Appropriately for researchers of politics, the process of negotiation between informants and researchers, and in our case within our research group, has to be seen as social, political and cultural processes. Looking further at processes of negotiation about knowledge within our group, our collective fieldwork log contains passages where we mull over what we are learning, each of us bringing slight differences in interpretation and emphasis.

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At times, we challenge each other for clarification, as in this passage (where 1–4 represent each researcher/author and x and y are politicians):

Researcher 1: On the issue of reflexivity about how we interview that we have been discussing, I was thinking that my way of operating, besides incorporating the humour we mentioned, is by seeking the spark of what I have in common with my interlocutors, so that I can be true to myself and respectful to the other person and we can together create something together in the moment. In this case with x (politician), we have in common the fact that he likes to create conflict and I love to unpack/unreveal it, so we are both obsessed by conflicts each in their own way.

Researcher 2: The contrast between x and y was incredibly illuminating. x gained votes entirely through social media; generates conflict to get more likes; champions causes that he thinks are of national importance, perhaps indicating his ambitions.

Researcher 3: About 50% of his followers are from the city of São Paulo, which completely explains why he is a candidate for federal deputy. He also said that he had the vote of 90% of his followers in São Paulo.

Researcher 4: Fascinating contrasts between x and y, between new and old styles of politics, between a politics played out in the 'new' public space of social media with no need for a physical locality and one deeply grounded in a 'territory'.

Researcher 1: I wouldn't say new and old style in the sense one will necessarily substitute the other. Do you mean that?

Researcher 4: Not that they're exclusive of each other, but it's a way of doing politics that's different because of the reach that social media offers – politicians could use the media before, but not in a way that places it in their own hands in the way social media works. I guess that's what I think of as 'new': the availability of a means of amplification and engagement that is significantly beyond what was available before.

In this discussion between the four of us about encounters with different politicians, we bring different knowledge into our interpretative narrative – writing with the authority of a polyphonic group with a temporary single voice. We are remembering, emphasizing and concluding on similar questions about how politicians relate to their publics from different aspects. To create a rigorous account, it is imperative that the group is able to inquire into different perspectives held by each other – anything less would constitute an authoritarian stamping of knowledge claims by one (or some) on others. So, whilst we, as a group of four researchers, gave ourselves the privilege of creating this article, excluding our interlocutors as authors even if they were co-creating theories, we have tried to retain some doubt and stay open to each other's ideas as we co-create knowledge in this text and any others we plan to write about Brazil. None of us has a bird's-eye superior view from

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which to interpret, but as a group we can expand on detached involvement in the political world we are studying. As Bernstein argues:

> This pluralistic clash energizes philosophic speculation and enlivens philosophical debate. Sometimes it is just the slings and arrows that we feel from those who oppose us that drive us to a more refined, subtle, and robust articulation of a philosophical orientation. This is the way in which I think it is best to view the development of pragmatism from Peirce to Brandom and Habermas. And as any good pragmatist knows, nobody finally has the last word.
>
> (2008, 51)

If we see research as a performative pedagogical process, and we are by no means the first to do so (e.g. Gerstl-Pepin and Gunzenhauser 2002), then learning through debate is far more complex than merely translating what is seen into words. We have adopted an ethnographic view shared with Peirano, according to which good ethnography has "to go beyond common sense as far as the use of language goes" (2014, 385). Following her perspective, we do not adopt a referential view of language as an instrument to simply describe reality, but we believe, like her, that "fieldwork is done through lived dialogue, which is then revealed through writing" (ibid.). As Peirano highlights, "words do things, bring about consequences, perform tasks, communicate, and produce results. And words are not the only means of communication: silence also communicates" (ibid.). Working as a group can create the potential for a far more rigorous way of handling what has been called a crisis of representation, but only if there is a shared commitment to recognizing this complexity, respecting each other's knowledge and being prepared for intense negotiation.

Notes

1 This is part of a project, "Ethnographies of Parliaments, Politicians and People," that has received funding from the European Research Council under the European Union's Horizon 2020 research and innovation programme (Grant agreement no. 8349986).
2 https://entanglementsjournal.org/about/, accessed 6 October 2022.
3 This programme, "Deepening Democracy" 2017–2021, was funded by the Arts and Humanities Research Council (AH/R005435/1), and its findings can be found on www.grnpp.org, accessed 6 October 2022.
4 www.iss.nl/en/media/robertchambershonoraryfellow, accessed 12 October 2022.
5 This can be found at: https://grnpp.org/ethnographies-of-parliaments/, accessed 14 December 2022.

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